century and, by 2010, the per capita income of Mauritius was three times that of India and several times higher than Bihar, the place where most Indo-Mauritians trace their roots. While most people speak Creole, a mixture of many languages, Bhojpuri is also spoken widely. At a smaller scale, even Hindi, Tamil, Telugu and Marathi are spoken, reflecting considerable cultural preservation. The Indian contact continues through tourism and investment as Mauritius is a popular honeymoon destination and also a tax haven that channelizes foreign portfolio investment (and illicit money transfers) into and out of India.

Mauritius is a part of the Mascarene Islands, which also includes Réunion and Rodrigues, the latter being an autonomous part of Mauritius. Réunion, earlier called Bourbon Island, is a French overseas department even today. In the 18th and 19th centuries, it imported Indian labour, mostly Tamilians, from the French settlements in India.[6] Slavery existed until 1848, and in 1860, under a treaty with the British, it began importing British Indian labour to expand sugar plantations. More than 20,000 Indians were brought in before migration was suspended in 1882 amidst growing chants of ill-treatment of labour. Gujarati merchants, Hindu and Muslim, also migrated in this period. In the 20th century, Indians assimilated within the French culture, such that three quarters of the population now identify themselves as having mixed origins. In fact, for some time, Indian-origin people even had to take Christian first names to meet the integrationist policies of the French. Today, churches, temples and mosques dot the island and people of Tamil descent make up a quarter of the population. Thus, the demographic and cultural evolution of Indians in Réunion differed from neighbouring Mauritius.

Most of the sugar consumed in western Europe during the colonial era was grown in the Caribbean islands and along the northern coast of Latin America. These were colonies of competing European empires whose political rule kept changing hands after several battles. In the 17th and 18th centuries, the sugar plantations depended heavily on African slave labour and from the middle of the 19th century, on Indian indentured labour. This part of the world was farther away from Mauritius, leading not only to